NASA Unveils $10 Billion Plan for a Moon Base by 2032

From: Space.com Mined: 2026-11-10 5 min read

NASA has big plans for the Moon. On Saturday, November 7, the space agency announced up to $10 billion in new **contracts** to help build a permanent moon base for astronauts by 2032.

The biggest piece is a new **framework** called CLPS 2, short for Commercial Lunar Payload Services. It is worth up to $10 billion over ten years. NASA picked eight companies to compete for missions under it: Blue Origin, Firefly Aerospace, Intuitive Machines, ispace-U.S., Lockheed Martin, Northrop Grumman, SpaceX and Voyager Technologies. NASA also raised the ceiling of its existing CLPS contract from $2.6 billion to $4.2 billion.

Why the change? NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman said the old contract was all or nothing, which worked for one or two missions a year. Scaling up needs flexibility to move pieces around, he said.

The plan also includes a **nuclear-powered** robot rover called PROMISE, short for Polar Rover for Observation, Mapping, and In-Situ Exploration. It will explore the Moon's south pole starting in late 2028, carrying a drill and science instruments to search for water ice and other **volatiles**. NASA gave Blue Origin a $94 million contract, with a possible $140 million more based on performance, to deliver PROMISE aboard its Blue Moon Mark 1 lander.

NASA also awarded about $1.3 billion in launch and transport work to Arrow Science and Technology, Blue Origin and Impulse Space. Those missions will test cargo transfers between Earth and lunar orbits, navigation with the CAPSTONE 2 spacecraft and lunar scouting with MoonFall drones. SpaceX will launch communications satellites aboard Starship in 2028.

All of this supports NASA's Phase One Moon Base strategy, which runs through 2029 and focuses on robots, **infrastructure** tests and commercial deliveries. Phase Two, from 2029 to 2032, will keep building the base.

Word Treasure

contracts -- Deals in which a company agrees to do work for money.

framework -- A plan that sets out how something big will be done.

volatiles -- Substances, like water ice, that can easily turn into gas.

nuclear-powered -- Powered by energy made inside atoms.

infrastructure -- The basic buildings and equipment a place needs to work.

Background you need

NASA is the United States space agency, and it sends astronauts and robots into space.

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite, and astronauts have never lived there for long stays, so a base would need homes, power and supplies brought from Earth.

Under its CLPS programme, NASA pays private companies to carry science tools and cargo to the Moon instead of building every lander itself.

Water ice at the Moon's south pole matters because it could be turned into drinking water, air and even rocket fuel for future trips.

Break it down

LEAD: NASA announced up to $10 billion in new contracts to build a permanent moon base by 2032.

KEY EVENT: NASA unveiled the CLPS 2 framework and other moon deals on Saturday, November 7.

+- WHO: NASA and eight companies picked to compete for missions under CLPS 2.

+- WHAT: A new framework worth up to $10 billion over ten years, plus a higher ceiling for the old CLPS contract.

+- WHY: The old all-or-nothing contract worked for one or two missions a year, but scaling up needs flexibility.

EVIDENCE: PROMISE, a nuclear-powered rover, will explore the south pole from late 2028, and about $1.3 billion in launch work will test cargo transfers, navigation and scouting.

NEXT STEPS: Phase One runs through 2029, and Phase Two, from 2029 to 2032, will keep building the base.

Why it matters

A moon base could become a home and workplace for astronauts far from Earth, and the robots, landers and tests in this plan are the first steps toward living and working on another world.

Test what you remember

1. How much could NASA's new moon contracts be worth in total?

- (A) Up to $2.6 billion
- (B) Up to $10 billion
- (C) Up to $1.3 billion
- (D) $94 million

2. What is CLPS 2?

- (A) A new framework for commercial lunar payload services
- (B) A nuclear-powered rover
- (C) A moon base for astronauts
- (D) A communications satellite

3. Which company will deliver the PROMISE rover to the Moon?

- (A) Blue Origin
- (B) SpaceX
- (C) Impulse Space
- (D) Lockheed Martin

4. What will PROMISE search for at the Moon's south pole?

- (A) Water ice and other volatiles
- (B) Signs of past astronauts
- (C) New craters
- (D) Moon rocks to bring back to Earth

5. When will PROMISE start exploring the Moon's south pole?

- (A) In 2029
- (B) In 2032
- (C) In 2030
- (D) In late 2028

6. What does Phase One of the Moon Base strategy focus on?

- (A) Launching communications satellites
- (B) Robots, infrastructure tests and commercial deliveries
- (C) Building homes for astronauts
- (D) Sending astronauts to live on the Moon

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman: Said the old contract was all or nothing and worked for one or two missions a year, while scaling up needs flexibility to move pieces around.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):